SIR in Bihar won't be possible here. This conspiracy has been exposed," he wrote. "Like CCTV, our 'PPTV' will be vigilant and thwart the BJP's plans."

No empty rhetoric. The SP is moving with unusual urgency. Sources say district units have begun shortlisting Booth Level Agents (BLAs). In many assembly segments, the search is proving slow; many potential volunteers are reluctant. Here, the district president has been named the fallback, so that the party is never formally unrepresented, says spokesperson Udayveer Singh.



MASTER PLAN An Election Commission post in X on the SRI

Takeaways

- **As month-long SIR rolls out, SP and BJP go into massive ground ops**
- **Won't let Bihar be repeated in UP, Akhilesh and Congress say**

To streamline things, the SP has activated a dedicated internal website and issued login credentials to all district heads. They are expected to upload daily updates. The party has also got going voter outreach in remote areas, with helpline numbers to assist those who struggle with paper work.

The BJP, confident in its deep booth-level machinery and system backing at the top, is approaching it methodically. Sources say it has finalised BLAs for all of UP's 162,000 polling stations, with the list for half of its 403 assembly segments submitted to the Election Commission (EC). The party expects its full ground deployment to pick up pace soon, as booth teams begin door-to-door reviews of deletions, additions and objections.

The BJP will give all booths a three-member structure: BLA-1 taps ground workers daily; BLA-2 liaises with the EC; 'booth pravasis', mostly elected representatives, handle trouble-shooting, supervision and coordination. Besides a layer of minders tracking every five booths, each assembly segment will get a war room to track BLA activity and be the backend for all ground-level paper work. Their hotlines will be plugged up the chain, to 75 district war rooms, which in turn feed a state command centre. A buzzing, pyramidal closed circuit.

AWARENESS DRIVES

Other parties are warming up too. The BSP has issued a booklet that distils EC guidelines into simpler language for its core base, and asked its Muslim/OBC 'bhaichara' committees to run awareness drives in their midst. The Congress leans more towards communication than scale. A state war room is up, and BLAs will be clustered into district-level WhatsApp groups. A national legal team will hold a training session in Lucknow for everyone. "We are being very vigilant. The mistakes of Bihar won't be repeated," says spokesperson Anshu Awasthi. ■

▶ ANDHRA PRADESH

A Big Nail In The Maoist Coffin

It's a preface to the final end as Chhattisgarh's most dreaded Maoist fighter falls

By **Rahul Noronha**

IT COULD HAVE BECOME ONE MORE HIGH-PROFILE MAOIST surrender, if it had panned out in one of the two ways Chhattisgarh was chalking it out. Last week, deputy CM Vijay Sharma had even had a lunch meeting with Madvi Hidma's mother, and an appeal was sent out to her son soon after to lay down arms, like many of his former confreres had done. The other option was old-fashioned: a gunbattle in the jungles. But of all the Maoist insurgents the security forces had faced off, he was the most lethal, the most adept at guerrilla warfare—and the most elusive. He was also the only one truly at home in Bastar.

Finally, when fate imposed the second option on Madvi Hidma, it happened far away from his native land. It was an ironic inversion. Almost all top positions in the Maoist hierarchy were and are held by Telu-

IN THE BUSH A file pic of Madvi Hidma in his younger days, in battle attire

